GigaWhat Energy

GigaWhat Gas
Controlled procedure

PR-GAS-003 Response to Reported Gas Escapes

Field	Value
Document ID	PR-GAS-003
Version	8
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Review due	2027-10-01
Owner	Head of Gas Network Operations
Approved by	Gas Safety Manager
Applies to	All GigaWhat Gas sites: low, medium and intermediate pressure mains and district governors

FICTIONAL DOCUMENT. Created for the GigaWhat demo. Not for real operational use.

1 Purpose

This procedure sets out how GigaWhat Gas responds to reported gas escapes, from the first call to handover to a repair team. It covers attendance standards, making safe, evacuation, gas in buildings and escalation.

2 Scope

This procedure applies to every report of a gas escape or smell of gas on or near the GigaWhat Energy network: LP, MP and IP mains (including MAIN-IP-01, MAIN-MP-03, MAIN-LP-17 and MAIN-LP-22), services, meters up to the emergency control valve, and district governors G-112, G-118 and G-124.

On a customer's installation beyond the emergency control valve, GigaWhat Energy makes safe only. Repairs there are for a registered gas engineer engaged by the customer.

3 References

- PR-GAS-021 Permit-to-Work for Gas Operations
- PR-GAS-040 Working in Hazardous Areas (DSEAR Zones)
- PR-GAS-052 Safe Excavation Near Live Gas Mains
- PR-CORP-001 Reporting Incidents and Near Misses
- PR-CORP-004 Lone Working
- Gas Safety (Management) Regulations 1996 and HSE guidance L80

- Dangerous Substances and Explosive Atmospheres Regulations 2002 (DSEAR) and HSE guidance L138
- Pipelines Safety Regulations 1996

4 Definitions

Uncontrolled escape: Any escape outside a building or on the network, or any escape inside where gas is still smelt after the emergency control valve has been turned off.

Controlled escape: An escape inside a property where the emergency control valve has been turned off and the smell has stopped.

Emergency control valve (ECV): The valve at the meter inlet that the customer uses to shut off the gas supply.

Gas in buildings: Gas inside a building that is entering from an external source, such as a leaking main or service.

LEL: Lower explosive limit, about 5% gas-in-air for natural gas. 20% LEL equals 1% gas-in-air.

5 Responsibilities

Gas Network Controller: Receives and classifies each report, dispatches a First Call Operative, monitors attendance and handles escalations.

First Call Operative: Attends, makes safe, decides on immediate evacuation, investigates gas in buildings and keeps the Gas Network Controller informed.

Authorised Person (Gas): Takes charge of escalated jobs, evacuations and gas-in-buildings incidents, authorises re-occupation and issues repair permits under PR-GAS-021.

Gas Safety Manager: Is informed of every evacuation, fire, explosion or injury.

6 Procedure

6.1 Receiving and dispatching the report

6.1.1 The Gas Network Controller records the caller's details, the address, and where the smell is and how strong.

6.1.2 Advise the caller to turn off the ECV if safe, open doors and windows, avoid electrical switches and naked flames, and leave the building if the smell is strong.

6.1.3 Classify the report as uncontrolled or controlled using section 4. If in doubt, classify it as uncontrolled.

6.1.4 Dispatch the nearest available First Call Operative. Attend uncontrolled escapes within 1 hour and controlled escapes within 2 hours of the report being received.

6.1.5 If an attendance standard is at risk, dispatch any available competent operative, including standby staff, and inform the on-call Authorised Person (Gas).

6.1.6 Call 999 immediately for any report of fire, explosion or injury.

6.2 Arrival and initial assessment

> WARNING: A flammable atmosphere may already be present. An electric doorbell, light switch or non-intrinsically safe phone can ignite it. Knock on doors and use only equipment permitted by PR-GAS-040.

6.2.1 Park outside the area where gas is smelt, upwind if possible.

6.2.2 Confirm your gas detector passed its start-of-shift bump test and zero it in clean air before approaching.

6.2.3 Tell the Gas Network Controller you have arrived so the attendance time is recorded, and start lone working check-ins under PR-CORP-004 if working alone.

6.2.4 Ask the caller where and when the smell was first noticed.

6.2.5 Enter and test at high level, near ceilings, and where services enter the building.

6.3 Making safe inside the property

6.3.1 Turn off the ECV if it is not already off.

6.3.2 Open doors and windows to ventilate, and put out any naked flames.

6.3.3 Test the meter and pipework upstream of the ECV with your detector and leak detection fluid.

6.3.4 If the escape is downstream of the ECV and readings fall to zero with the ECV off, leave the ECV off, fit a warning label and advise the customer to contact a registered gas engineer.

6.3.5 If the escape is upstream of the ECV, on GigaWhat Energy's service or meter inlet, keep the area ventilated and ask the Gas Network Controller for a repair team.

6.3.6 If gas is still detected with the ECV off, or readings are rising, treat it as gas in buildings and follow 6.5 and 6.6.

6.4 Evacuation decisions

> WARNING: Gas at or above 20% LEL inside a building can reach the flammable range quickly. Delaying evacuation can cost lives.

6.4.1 Evacuate the building immediately if any reading in a room, cellar or void is 20% LEL or above, or if readings are rising and the source cannot be found.

6.4.2 Evacuate adjoining properties that share walls, cellars or ducts with a building where gas from an external source has been found.

6.4.3 Send evacuated people to a safe place upwind and at least 50 m away, and check that everyone is accounted for.

6.4.4 Tell the Gas Network Controller immediately of every evacuation, and ask for police and fire service support through 999 if more than one property is evacuated.

6.4.5 Where readings are below 20% LEL and falling, keep occupants out of affected rooms and re-test every 15 minutes.

> HOLD POINT: Do not allow anyone back into an evacuated building until the Authorised Person (Gas) has confirmed that the source is controlled and no gas has been detected in any room, void or cellar for at least 30 minutes.

6.5 Gas in buildings: checks inside

> NOTE: This subsection and 6.6 replace the separate gas-in-buildings procedure, PR-GAS-071.

6.5.1 Ask the Gas Network Controller to send the on-call Authorised Person (Gas) as soon as gas from an external source is suspected.

6.5.2 Test every room, cupboard and cellar, concentrating on points where gas, water, electricity, telecoms and drainage services enter.

6.5.3 Test under-floor voids and wall cavities through airbricks, weep holes or lifted floorboards.

6.5.4 Test the adjoining properties on both sides and the properties opposite, including their cellars and voids.

6.5.5 Ventilate affected voids and cellars by opening airbricks, doors and hatches where safe to do so.

6.5.6 Record each reading, its location and time on a sketch, and re-test every 15 minutes.

6.6 Gas in buildings: tracing the external source

> CAUTION: Bar holes can strike cables and pipes. Scan with a cable avoidance tool and follow PR-GAS-052 before driving any bar hole.

6.6.1 Test drains, inspection chambers, utility boxes, valve covers and cracks in the road or footway near the building.

6.6.2 Drive bar holes about 450 mm deep at no more than 2 m intervals along the line of the service and the main, keeping at least 150 mm above the known depth of any pipe.

6.6.3 Test each bar hole and plot the readings to find the highest concentration, which indicates the likely source.

6.6.4 Leave bar holes open between the source and the building so gas vents to atmosphere rather than into the building.

6.6.5 Give the readings plot to the Authorised Person (Gas) and the repair team on arrival.

6.7 Escapes at district governors and on MP or IP mains

> WARNING: Escapes from MP and IP mains and governors release gas at high flow and can form a large flammable cloud. Do not operate network valves or governor equipment unless instructed by the Authorised Person (Gas).

6.7.1 Set up a cordon of at least 25 m around an MP escape or a district governor, and at least 50 m around an IP escape, adjusting for wind and buildings.

6.7.2 Keep vehicles, people and ignition sources out of the cordon.

6.7.3 Report the escape immediately to the Gas Network Controller with the asset ID, for example MAIN-IP-01 or G-118.

6.7.4 Check buildings within the cordon for gas following 6.5.

6.8 Escalation to the Gas Network Controller

6.8.1 Escalate immediately when: gas from an external source is found in a building; any building is evacuated; the escape is on an MP or IP main or at a district governor; there is fire, explosion or injury; or you need more resources.

6.8.2 Escalate if an uncontrolled escape cannot be made safe within 1 hour of your arrival.

6.8.3 The Gas Network Controller then informs the on-call Authorised Person (Gas), dispatches a repair team, and considers reducing network pressure or isolating the main.

6.8.4 The Gas Network Controller informs the Gas Safety Manager of every evacuation, fire, explosion or injury.

6.9 Handover and emergency contacts

6.9.1 Do not leave site while there is an uncontrolled escape or gas in a building until the Authorised Person (Gas) or the repair team has taken over.

6.9.2 Brief the repair team on readings, bar holes, evacuated properties and ECVs turned off, then tell the Gas Network Controller when you leave.

6.9.3 Call 999 for fire, explosion or injury.

6.9.4 If you cannot reach the Gas Network Controller by radio, call the National Gas Emergency Service on 0800 111 999 and ask for the GigaWhat Gas Network Controller.

6.9.5 Report every fire, explosion, injury, evacuation and missed attendance standard under PR-CORP-001.

7 Records

The Gas Network Controller's job record holds the report time, classification, attendance time, escalations and closure. The First Call Operative records readings, evacuation decisions, ECVs turned off and labels fitted. Gas-in-buildings sketches and readings plots are attached. Records are kept for 10 years.

8 Revision history

Version	Date	Change
1	2009-04-06	First issue.
2	2011-03-07	Added attendance standards.
3	2013-06-03	Added evacuation criteria based on % LEL readings.
4	2015-10-05	Added cordon distances for MP and IP escapes.
5	2017-09-04	Gas-in-buildings investigation moved to new procedure PR-GAS-071.
6	2019-10-07	Added lone working check-ins.
7	2022-10-03	Added district governor escapes and scanning before bar holing.
8	2025-10-01	Gas-in-buildings checks from PR-GAS-071 brought back into this procedure (6.5 and 6.6) and PR-GAS-071 withdrawn. Clarified escalation to the Gas Network Controller and added a hold point on re-occupation.